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A return to a life they knew

MassWildlife program helps paraplegic hunters get back to the woods



By Ben Pennington and Katie Muchnick
GLOBE CORRESPONDENTS

When Fred Baker fractured his spine in a motorcycle accident in 2009, his first thought was how he would continue his hobbies — skiing, motorcycling, fishing at his family’s lake house, and hunting.

“The injury was the injury,” Baker said. “My activities are my big thing. I live more for those.”

Since becoming paralyzed from the waist down, Baker has figured out how to ski (using a mono-ski) and how to get out of his truck. He’s in the market for another motorcycle. And he hunts through a statewide “parahunt” put on by MassWildlife.

Each year, staff and volunteers help hunters with paraplegia travel to locations across the state for a three-day shoot. When a hunter shoots a deer, they assist by retrieving, field dressing, and transporting the deer.

Baker, 40, has been hunting his entire life, and kept at it with his friends’ assistance after being injured. But the camaraderie of the statewide parahunt — which he discovered through a wheelchair basketball friend — keeps him coming back.

HUNTING, Page A10



PHOTOS BY BEN PENNINGTON FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Top, after firing two shots, Fred Baker made his way down a dirt road to examine the deer he targeted while out on the MassWildlife parahunt. Above, Baker and his mother, Maria Baker, tried out the venison roast he made from the deer.

Netflix deal for Warner Bros. poised to sharply alter industry’s balance of power

By Brooks Barnes, Lauren Hirsch, and Nicole Sperling
NEW YORK TIMES

Netflix on Friday announced plans to acquire Warner Bros. Discovery’s studio and streaming business, in a deal that will send shock waves through Hollywood and the broader media landscape.

Netflix is already the world’s largest paid streaming service, with more than 300 million subscribers. Bulk-ing up with Warner Bros. Discovery assets would create a colossus with greater leverage over theater owners

and entertainment-industry unions. It could force smaller companies to merge as they scramble to compete.

►What may happen next? And what about subscribers? D1.

The acquisition would also complete the conquest of Hollywood by tech insurgents. Instead of acquiring studios, tech companies have mostly grown under their own steam in Hollywood. In 2022, Amazon closed its \$8.5 billion acquisition of Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer, home to James Bond and Rocky franchises.

“In a world where people have so many choices, more choices than ever on how to spend their time, we can’t stand still,” Ted Sarandos, Netflix’s co-CEO, said on a conference call. “We need to keep innovating and investing in stories that matter most to audiences, and that’s what this deal is all about. The combination of Netflix and Warner Bros. creates a better Netflix for the long run.”

The cash-and-stock deal values the business at \$82.7 billion, including debt. The acquisition is expected to close after Warner Bros. Discovery

NETFLIX, Page A10

Viral videos leading skiers astray, to frustration of Vt. rescue squad

Lured to off-trail powder, many get lost and call for help

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

A Vermont search-and-rescue organization is taking to social media to warn of the perils of social media, saying viral videos are leading skiers to make dangerous decisions that ultimately require its volunteers to mobilize.

“TikTok videos of whooping skiers in knee-deep powder are luring inexperienced skiers and riders into Stowe’s backcountry,” Stowe Mountain Rescue wrote on Facebook this week.

The town rescue squad described an “unprecedented number of lost skiers” who had accessed the backcountry from Stowe Mountain Resort this snowy early

season — only to contact first responders when they became stranded.

One group requiring a rescue cited a TikTok video as its inspiration.

On Nov. 29, two 19-year-olds from New York City, a skier and a snowboarder, slipped out of the resort near its Toll Road trail and eventually became disoriented, according to Stowe Mountain Rescue chief Jon Wehse. As night fell, they called authorities for help. The squad, made up of volunteers, sent in a crew on ATVs and picked up the pair without incident.

When the two were asked what drew them into the woods, according to Wehse, “They said, ‘We saw this on TikTok.’”

“We have a lot of clueless people out here who are chasing a dream,” Wehse said. “They’re chasing a pow shot.”

Drew Clymer, search and rescue coordinator for the Vermont Department

RESCUES, Page A6

CDC panel backs later vaccine for hepatitis B

Change would be biggest to come under RFK Jr.

By Helen Branswell
STAT

A panel that advises on US vaccine policy voted on Friday to recommend a delay in when most babies begin to be vaccinated against hepatitis B, overturning a 30-year-old policy that has contributed to a massive decline in cases of the virus.

The Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices voted 8-3 to recommend the change, following more than a day of contentious discussion. The new recommendation is that parents should discuss with their doctors whether to give the hepatitis B vaccine at birth, or at all, and that those who choose to do so should wait to begin the vaccine series until their baby is at least 2 months old.

That recommendation applies to mothers who test negative for hepatitis B during their pregnancy. The previous recommendation, in place since 1991, was that all babies receive a dose of hepatitis B vaccine at birth.

The change has to be endorsed by Jim O’Neill, the acting director of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, or by Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. before it becomes part of the CDC vaccination schedule.

The vote was quickly denounced by Senator Bill Cassidy, Republican of Louisiana and a physician whose support was critical to Kennedy securing Senate confirmation. Cassidy urged federal health officials to reject it.

HEPATITIS B, Page A7

NIH chief defends new funding model

In Mass. visit, says he wants ‘level playing fields’

By Jonathan Saltzman, Kay Lazar, Chris Serres, and Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

Dr. Jay Bhattacharya, director of the National Institutes of Health, defended his agency’s plan Friday to move more research funding to the heartlands — a move many fear could lead to fewer dollars for Massachusetts and undermine one of the state’s major economic engines.

“I want Iowa, Nebraska scientists, scientists at every institution, to be able to compete on the same level playing fields with the brilliant scientists here in Massachusetts,” he said in an exclusive interview with the Globe.

His remarks came during a visit to Massachusetts, the state with the most NIH funding per capita, whose research ecosystem has been ravaged by layoffs and funding cuts. His meetings with scientists, biomedical executives, and doctors were largely respectful, but sometimes contentious.

Under Bhattacharya’s leadership, the NIH has said it will prioritize “geographic balance” in fund-

NIH, Page A7

The two survivors of the US military’s first boat strike on Sept. 2 climbed atop the overturned hull and waved to something overhead, according to people who have seen video of the attack. **A2.**

The Supreme Court said that it would hear a landmark dispute over the constitutionality of President Trump’s effort to end birth-right citizenship. **A6.**



Architect Frank Gehry has died

The visionary behind the Guggenheim Museum in Bilbao, Spain, was 96. **C9.**

Shiver me timbers

Saturday: Mostly cloudy. High: 35-40. Low: 28-33.
Sunday: Sun and clouds. High: 34-39. Low: 23-28.
High tide: 11:35 a.m.
Sunrise: 6:59 Sunset: 4:11
Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**

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SETTING THE FIFA STAGE



JESS RAPFOGEL/GETTY IMAGES

Tom Brady, Wayne Gretzky, Shaquille O’Neal, and Aaron Judge served as draw assistants at the FIFA World Cup 2026 Official Draw in Washington on Friday. The event produced a short list of countries that are in contention to play in Boston’s five group-stage games in June. **C1.**